Reminder: Fill the room on October 27!

Protect South Portland <protectsouthportland@23988339.mailchir Oct 25, 2026 at 9:33 AM
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PSP

PROTECT SOUTH PORTLAND

Reminder:
Fill the room on October 27!

****Tell our leaders to stop tank farms from dumping hazardous pollutants in our neighborhoods.****

What: City Council workshop
When: Tuesday, Oct. 27 at 6:00 p.m.
Where: South Portland High School (637 Highland Avenue).

Let's fill the room!

Email the City Council before the workshop and ask them to pressure the DEP to stop tank farms from dumping pollutants into our neighborhoods.
City Council email addresses:
https://southportland.gov/411/City-Council

Here are some additional points to remember as you craft letters and comment:

- **Stop the tank farms from dumping pollutants in our neighborhoods.**
- **Tank farms have been shown to be bad neighbors time and time again.** They've been sued for violating their permits; they've been fined for violating fuel quality standards of the Clean Air Act; their emissions are in violation of Maine's ambient air guidelines.
- **The self-reported emissions numbers have a documented history of being wrong.** EPA-mandated third-party testing in 2012-2013 found Global and Sprague in serious violation of their permits and the Clean Air Act, and the EPA ultimately sued both companies for underreporting their emissions.
- **The 2019 consent decrees didn't fix the underlying problem.** They brought fines and odor control technology for Global and Sprague, but included no binding requirements for ongoing monitoring or mitigation of hazardous air pollutants, which is why residents' concerns have continued.
- **The tank farms are allowed to pollute at a massive scale.** Under their current Maine DEP licenses, South Portland's tank farms are collectively permitted to emit approximately 600 tons of volatile organic compounds and approximately 100 tons of hazardous air pollutants, including benzene, every year.
- **Tank farms may not even be operating to their full capacity and already we are seeing health-harming benzene levels.** We don't know how much product is actually being moved through or stored in tanks, to understand how the high readings for benzene and other HAPs relate to how much product (or throughput) is being moved through the tank farms and when.
- **No one is accounting for the tanks' combined, cumulative impact.** With six tank farms clustered together near homes, schools, daycares, and parks, DEP should adopt a

"source aggregation" framework that licenses each facility based on the combined pollution burden on the neighborhood, not facility by facility in isolation.

- **Two "major emitters" have been waived out of pollution controls, because they estimate their own emissions.** Citgo and South Portland Terminal are both classified as major emitters, yet both are exempt from hazardous air pollutant control requirements because they self-report emissions below the regulatory threshold, using formulas created by the American Petroleum Institute, the industry's own lobbying group.
- **Data confirms what residents have said for years.** In addition to the concerning benzene spikes coming from areas near tanks at Bug Light, the first full year of fenceline monitoring, released in 2025, shows benzene near Citgo and South Portland Terminal consistently and dramatically exceeding Maine's ambient air guidelines. One reading at South Portland Terminal measured 12 times the state standard. And the averages at that same site were as high as 4.5 times the AAG.
- **DEP's own September 2026 report downplays long-term risk.** The report focuses on health impacts from acute/short-term exposure, but benzene is a known human carcinogen with no safe exposure level according to the World Health Organization, and long-term exposure is causally linked to leukemia and other blood disorders, a special concern for the children, seniors, and immunocompromised residents who live, play, and go to school near these tanks. We all are experiencing both short-term spikes of toxic emissions, as well as long-term exposure of routinely high levels of these pollutants.
- **The Maine DEP holds regulatory power and responsibility over the tank farms in South Portland.** Department leaders have the ability to use the regulations that already exist to do more to protect the people of South Portland. If they need more or different authority, they have the discretion to ask the Legislature for it. What they need is the will to act.
- **Call on the City to demand that the DEP fulfill its charge of environmental protection.** The state's own air emissions

standards are being violated. *Many* South Portlanders live close to tank farms and, more picnic at Bug Light, run on the Greenbelt, or drop their children off each day at daycares or schools close to the tanks. We know enough that failing to act to protect this community would be a clear dereliction of duty by the DEP. The city council should say so.

Please consider donating to Protect South Portland by following this link. Your donations are greatly appreciated and will help us continue our important work in educating and preparing communities for the challenges ahead. Thank you for your contribution!

Email: Protect South Portland

To promote actions and practices that serve to protect
the environment and the health and welfare of South Portland.

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